



Philosophy

#5: Epistemology

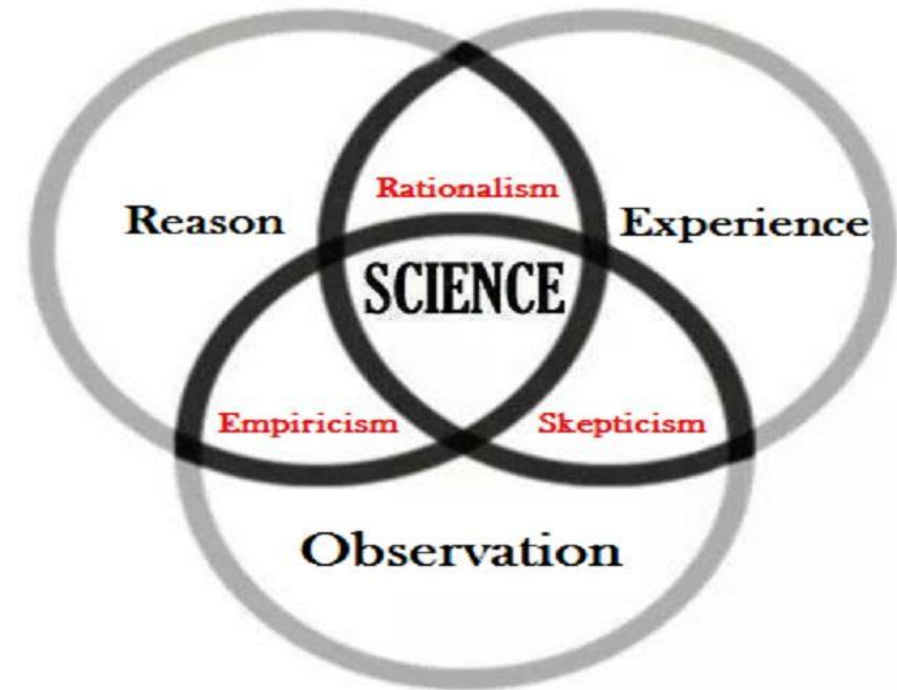
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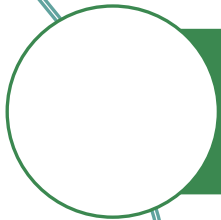
MASTER IN PHILOSOPHY, UOK

Course Content

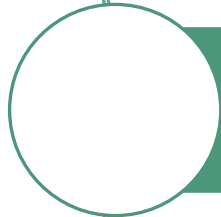
1. Rationalism
2. Empiricism
3. Pragmatism
4. Scientism



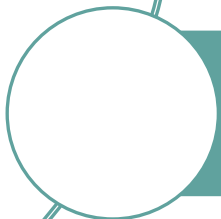
Critical questions



What are the sources of knowledge?



How do we know the truth ?



Can we know the truth?

A cartoon illustration of an elephant with several people touching it from different angles, each making a different conclusion based on their limited perspective. Speech bubbles include: "It's a Fan!" (ear), "It's a Wall!" (side), "It's a Rope!" (tail), "It's a Tree!" (leg), "It's a Snake!" (foot), and "It's a Snake!" (tusk).

Epistemology

Epistemology is the branch of philosophy that studies knowledge. It attempts to answer the basic question: what distinguishes true knowledge from false knowledge?

“The theory or science of the method or grounds of knowledge.”

—Webster’s Dictionary

“The branch of philosophy that is concerned with the theory of knowledge. It is an inquiry into the nature and source of knowledge, the bounds of knowledge, and the justification of claims to knowledge.”

—Feinberg

Sources of Knowledge:

composed of ideas formed from observable data.

knowledge obtained through the five bodily Senses.

knowledge that is revealed through experience.

Knowledge is gained from empirical evidences.

Knowledge is attained from scientific observation.

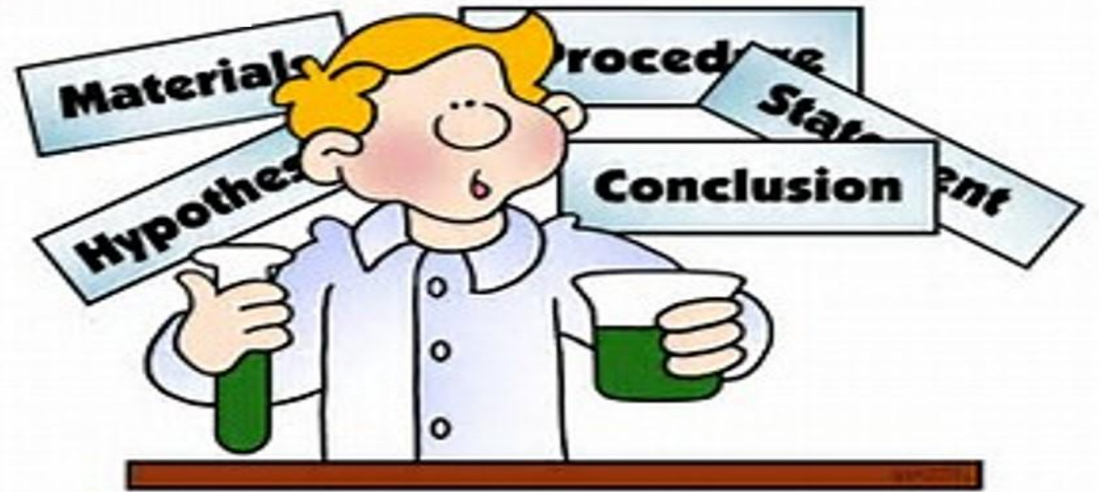


1.RATIONALISM

IDEAS ARE INNATE IN OUR MIND

Thought vs Experiment

Rationalism $\neq$ Science



RATIONALISM

- **Intellect** is an independent source of knowledge about the world.
- It emphasized on **rational** capacity of human mind to know the truth.
- All ideas are innate in mind which is recognized by **reason alone**.
- Mind whose essential attribute is “**thought**”, a key source of knowing.
- Some famous rationalist thinkers are **Descartes, Leibnitz & Spinoza**.
- Descartes said “*I think therefore I exist.*”
- Spinoza said “*The cause of all things is innate in mind.*”
- Leibnitz said “*There are 2 kinds of truth: reason & facts*”

Rationalism : Key Ideas

1. **Innate Ideas:** Some ideas or knowledge are inborn or inherent in the human mind.
2. **Deductive Reasoning:** Knowledge is derived from logical principles and mathematical truths.
3. **A Priori Knowledge:** Knowledge that is independent of sensory experience.

Descartes(1596-1650)

Cogito ergo sum-I think therefore I exist

- **René Descartes** was the “father” of modern philosophy, a rationalist, and a dualist.
- He said there are **two separate and distinct substances**: material substance i-e body and non-material substance i-e mind.
- There is nothing of which can be certain so do doubt on external world.
- **Doubting** is form of thinking that lead toward true knowledge.
- Believe in own existence cannot be doubted
- I think therefore I am, I exist. It is direct self evident intuition.
- We inquire all sort of knowledge from rational thinking.
- I am a thinking being and have innate ideas in my mind.
- He emphasized innate knowledge and rational deduction.

Spinoza (1632-1677)

“The cause of all things is innate in mind.”

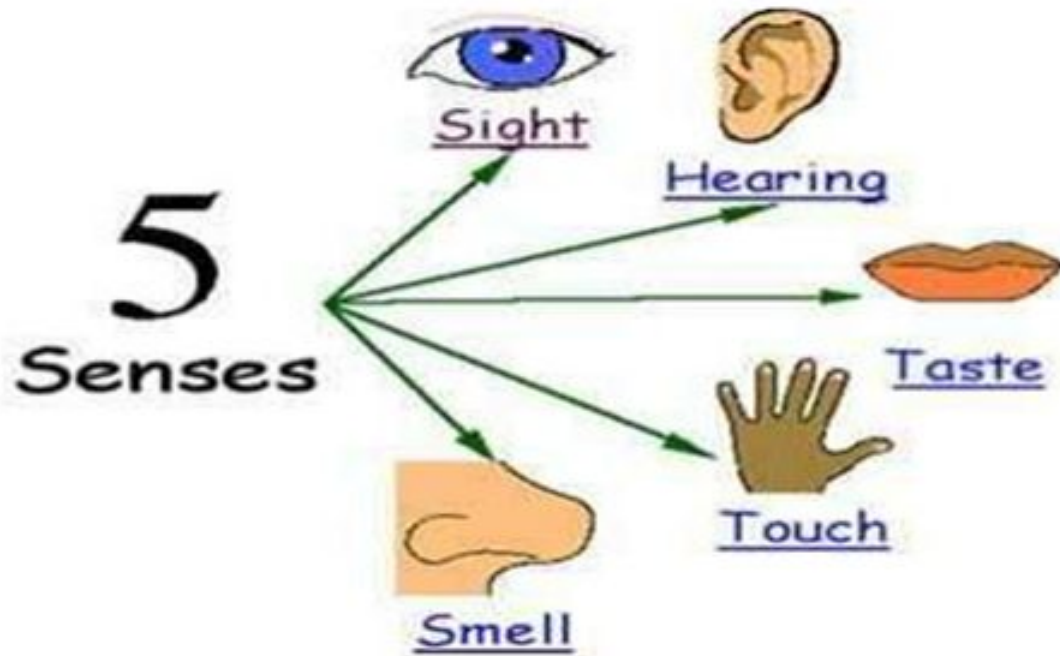
- **Spinoza** was a **monist** and Continental rationalist.
- He maintained that thought and extension are attributes of a single infinite substance.
- He argued for reality of which everything else is a mode. **single, infinite** substance (God or Nature).
- The Knowledge of the world comes through understanding the essential nature of reality.
- He argued that knowledge arises from rational understanding and not sensory experience.

Leibnitz (1646-1716)

“There are 2 kinds of truth: reason & facts”

- Leibniz was a Continental rationalist.
- He proposed that reality is made up of countless simple, indivisible, mind-like substances called **monads**.
- He held that the ultimate constituents of reality are monads, which are nonmaterial, indivisible units of force.
- He developed the idea of monads, which are indivisible and dynamic units of reality.
- He argued that reason, logic, and innate ideas are central to understanding the world.
- Everything that exists has a reason for its existence, even if we don't know it.
- Argued that God has **pre-establish** the monads to act in harmony, explaining apparent causal interactions without direct interaction.

Empiricism



Ideas and knowledge develop in our minds as a result of our sensory experiences.

2.EMPIRICISM

Ideas comes from experience

Empiricism

- Experience is an independent source of knowledge in spite of mind only.
- All ideas and knowledge are acquired through interaction with the world.
- Senses-perception is reliable method of attaining truth and reality.
- We perceive objects indirectly by our representations in perceive mind.
- Mind is clean slate or tabula rasa which means it has no innate ideas.
- Hume said “Custom is the great guide of human life.”
- Locke said “No knowledge go beyond experience.”
- Berkley said “To be is to be perceived.”

Empiricism: key ideas

1. **Tabula Rasa:** The mind starts as a blank slate, and experiences shape knowledge.
2. **Inductive Reasoning:** Knowledge is derived from observation and experience of the world.
3. **A Posteriori Knowledge:** Knowledge that depends on experience or empirical data.

Locke(1632-1704)

“No knowledge go beyond experience.”

- **John Locke** was a father of British empiricism.
- He held that we perceive objects indirectly by **means of our perceptions** of them.
- He believed that ideas would be accurate copies of the real properties of objects.
- He advocated the "tabula rasa" theory, which states that the mind is a blank slate at birth, and knowledge comes from sensory experiences.
- He argued that the mind receives *simple ideas* directly from sensation (e.g., redness, hardness) and reflection (e.g., thinking, willing).
- **Primary qualities** (inherent in the object, like shape, size, motion).
- **Secondary qualities** (qualities that produce sensations in us, like color, taste, sound, which are dependent on the perceiver).

Berkley(1685-1753)

“To be is to be perceived.”Esse est percipi

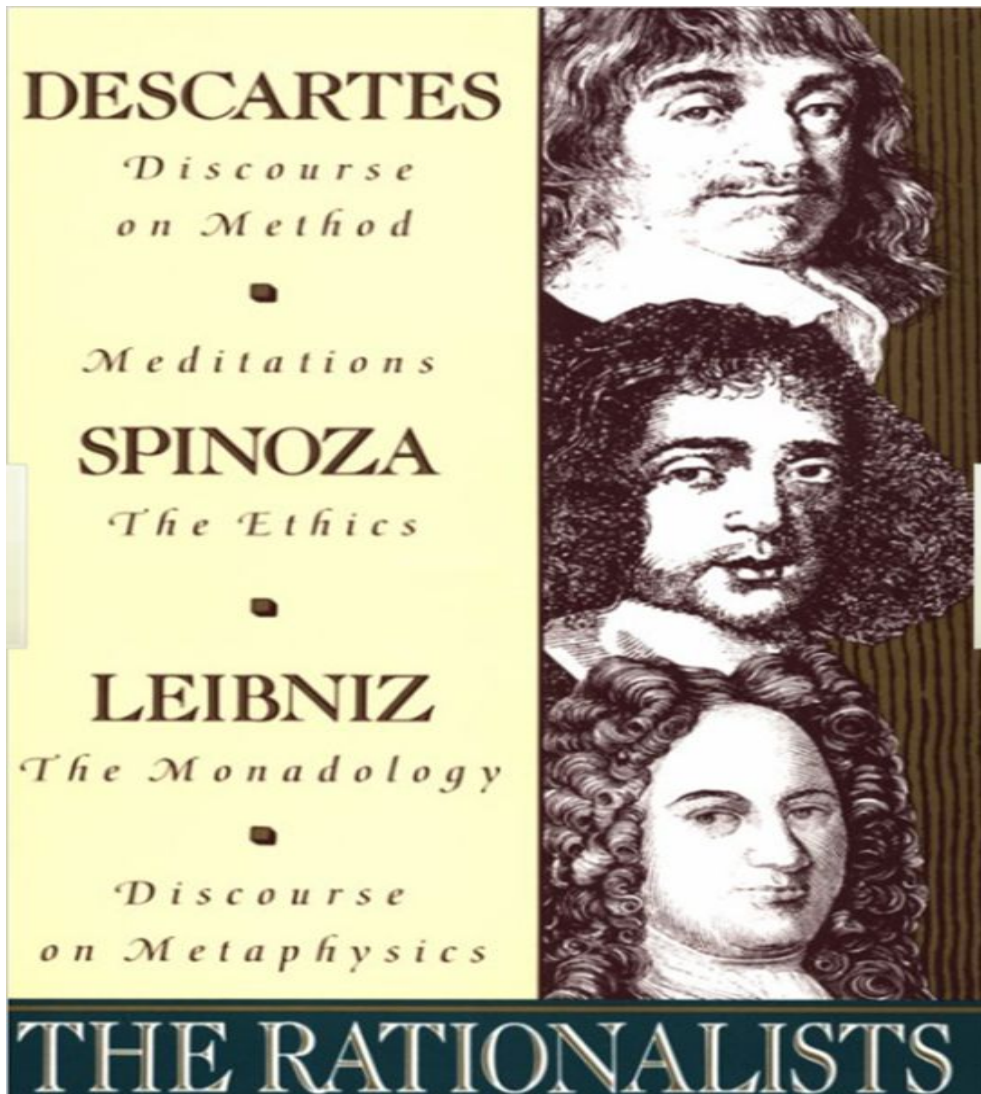
- **George Berkeley** was a British empiricist and idealist.
- He who denied the existence of material substance and held that ***sensible objects exist only in the mind.***
- He is Known for his theory of “**subjective idealism**” which posits that material objects only exist as perceptions in the mind.
- He rejected the idea of a material world outside of perception.
- He believed that Knowledge comes through perception, and reality is dependent on sensory experience.
- He believed that only minds and their ideas exist.
- Material objects do not exist independently of being perceived. God's constant perception sustains the existence of the world.

Hume (1711-1776)

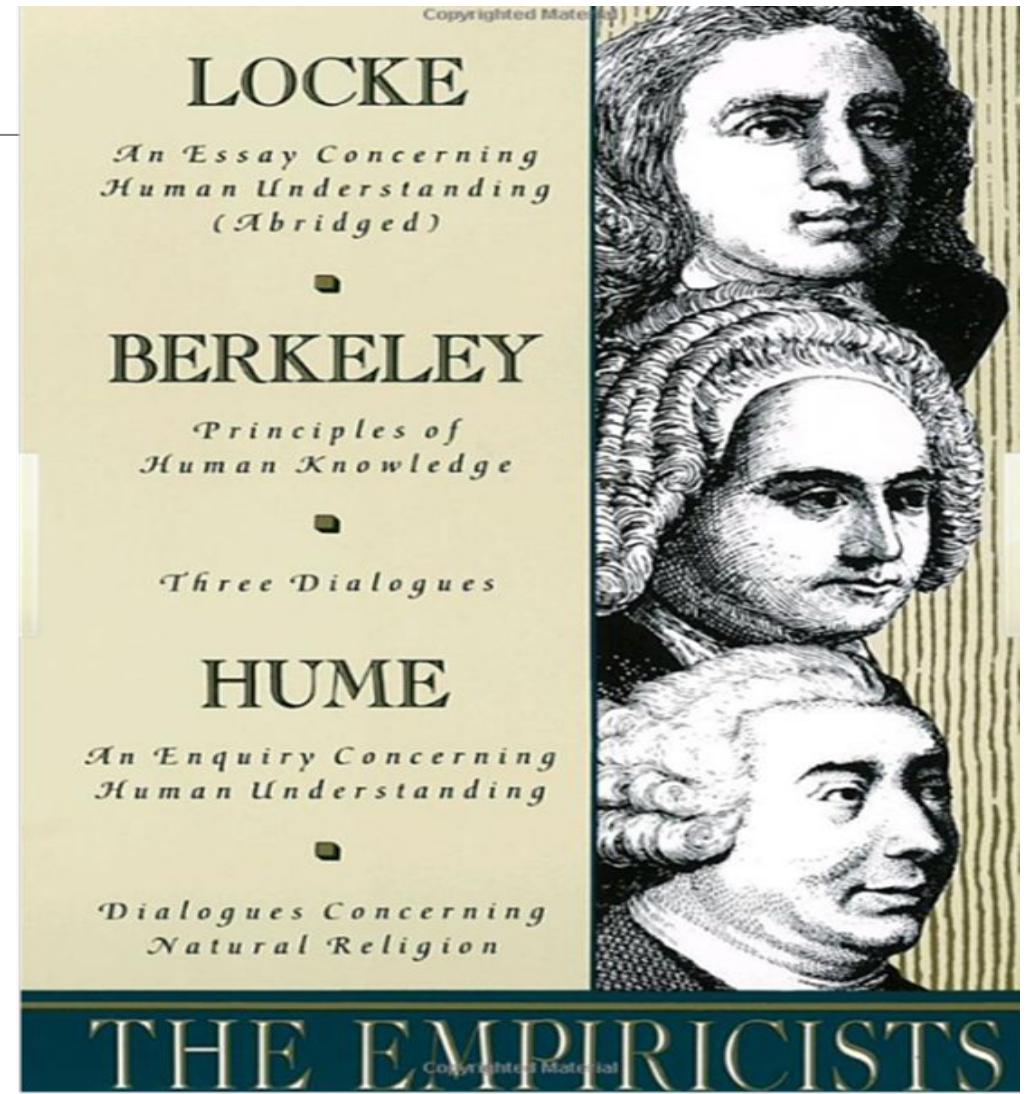
“Custom is the great guide of human life.”

- **David Hume** held that there is no metaphysical knowledge and maintained that **knowledge is limited to what we experience**.
- He summoned powerful arguments to question our supposed knowledge of the self, causality and the external world.
- He emphasized that all knowledge comes from sensory impressions, and questioned the nature of causality.
- He questioned the validity of inductive reasoning and argued that knowledge is ultimately based on experience and impressions.
- His skepticism about causality and human understanding had a profound impact on philosophy.

Further readings



Versus



Differences

RATIONALISM

- Mind has innate ideas.
- They rely on reason comes from mind only.
- Sensation is the source of knowing.
- Knowledge is prior before experience.
- Knowledge is based on experimentation.
- Experience does not produce certainty.
- Mathematics is the paradigm of knowledge.
- It is mainly deductive form of reasoning.

EMPIRICISM

- Mind is blank slate.
- They rely on merely experiences.
- Reason is the key source of knowing.
- Knowledge comes after experiences.
- Knowledge is based on use of logic.
- Reason is just an armchair discussion.
- Scientific experiment is the paradigm.
- It is mainly inductive form of reasoning.

Immanuel Kant (1724-1804)

Transcendental Idealism:

Kant argued that all knowledge begins with experience (empiricist), it does not arise entirely from experience.

The mind organizes sensory input using innate categories of understanding (rationalist).

He believed that we can only know phenomena (appearances), not noumena (things-in-themselves).

This synthesis attempted to reconcile the strengths of both positions, acknowledging the role of both experience and the mind's inherent structure in the formation of knowledge.

Summary

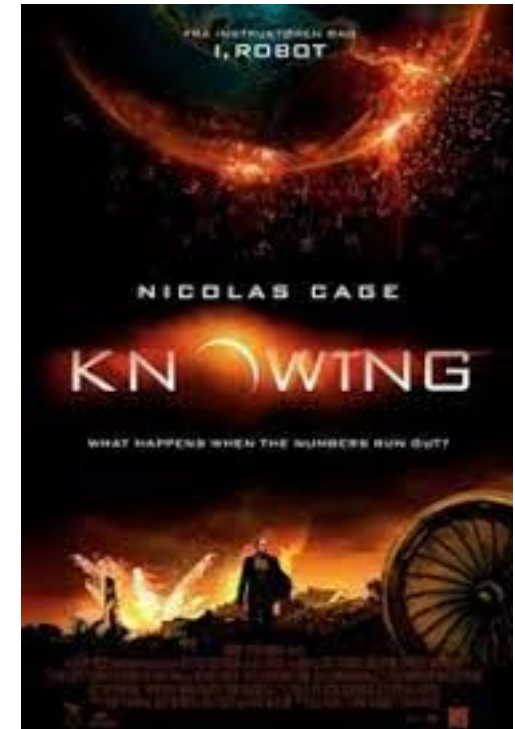
Rationalism: It makes sense for reason

Empiricism: It believe in experiment and evidence.

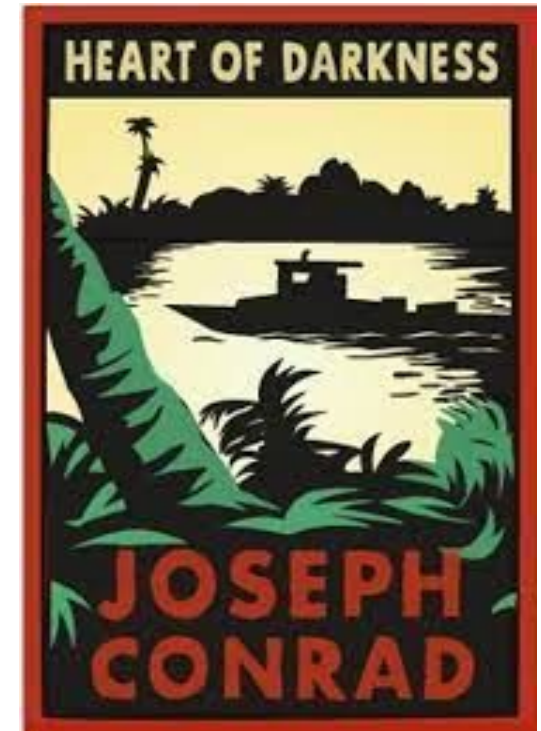
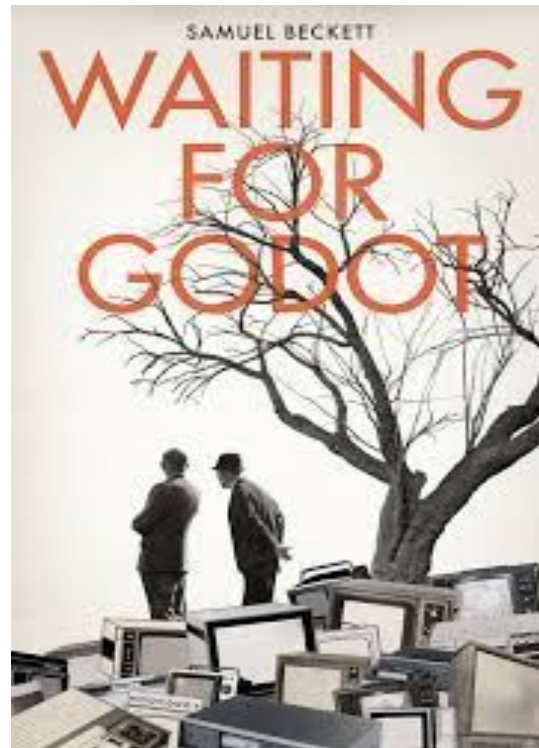
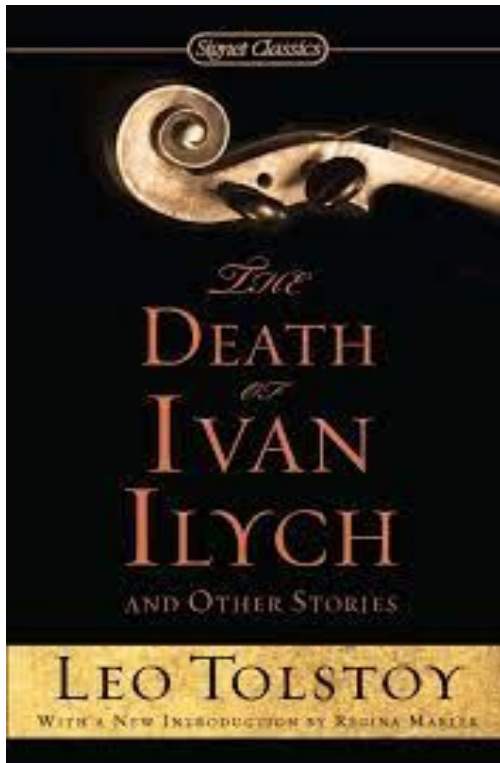
Pragmatism : It is based on practical experience.

Science: It can be demonstrated to be so.

Movie review on Epistemology



Literature review on Knowing



1

Those thinker who believe that knowledge comes from empirical evidence.

- a) Empiricism
- b) Rationalism
- c) Scientism
- d) Pragmatism

2

Who believe that our mind has innate ideas.

- a) Scientist
- b) Empiricist
- c) Rationalist
- d) Realist

3

Epistemology is the branch of philosophy which refers to:

- a) a statistical test.
- b) study of knowledge.
- c) a software package.
- d) a form of interviewing.

4

Which is the sub-branch of epistemology deals with the correct form of reasoning.

- a. Ethics
- b. Logic
- c. Epistemology
- d. Metaphysics

5

The word Episteme means :

- a) Wisdom
- b) Wonder
- c) Knowledge
- d) Reality